



“Women [perhaps] inherently have a better eye for detail and better time management since they need to deal with issues at home as well”

ATRAYEE SANYAL

Vice President (Human Resource Management), Tata Steel

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profile Mumbai-Ahmedabad high speed rail corridor project (MAHSR). She says that each project has been unique, though the Mumbai monorail is what she calls the “most challenging job” ever. “It involves a lot of thinking outside the box and coming up with innovative construction methods to navigate the city’s urban landscape,” explains Bhavani.

The Hyderabad metro is the largest PPP (public-private partnership) project in the world, with the design being done by the company in-house. That experience has clearly stood her in good stead. That said, a lot of interest remains for the MAHSR. “The speed of construction for this has been unheard of in India. It has redefined the way large-scale projects are executed by establishing a unique supplier ecosystem,” she says.

IT’S TIME FOR CHANGE

It is interesting to examine why in the past, there were fewer women in

the core sectors. A peek into the past throws up a world where manufacturing was male dominated ostensibly because of the physical effort involved. That has changed quite dramatically for many reasons, but nothing has possibly had as much of an impact as the emergence of digitalisation and automation on the shop floors.

Raman Kumar Singh, CHRO at ABB India, a tech leader in electrification and automation, says his company has more than doubled the proportion of women in the workforce over the past four years, from 9% to 20%. He emphasises on the role of technology, with the impact reflecting in an environment that is gender neutral.

“Automation has significantly reduced the need for manual labour or the strenuous tasks on the shop floor. Robots, conveyor systems and automated machines now handle much of the heavy lifting, making factory work more about operating, monitoring and maintaining technology,” he says.

Processes that are digitally con-

trolled allow for remote management. “That leads to more flexibility in job roles and breaking barriers that might have discouraged women from taking up jobs on the shop floor,” he adds.

Companies, too, are being more strategic about their recruitment process. Tata Steel’s Sanyal says that the “catch them young” approach—which essentially means identifying students in the second or third year of college—is one way of doing it.

For that matter, around 35% of her company’s recruits from the IITs and IIMs are women. “While this is not always a conscious attempt, if there are two good candidates, we go for the woman,” Sanyal says.

Again, technology’s role in having, say, a digital blast furnace has helped to manufacture steel in a less hazardous environment. “We are barely at the tip of the iceberg and automation will be a bigger enabler to increase the proportion of women in an industry like ours,” adds Sanyal.